Critical and Speculative Translation Fictions

Participatory Translation as a Mean of Social and Cultural Critique

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Abstract

Speculative research is a future-oriented approach using speculation for critical inquiry on the present and to imagine alternatives to current ideological discourses about the future. It is rooted in the use of design for social critique rather than as enabler of industrial production. In this paper, I outline my attempt to combine its methodologies with existing Translation Studies approaches with a similar nature. First, I describe the characteristics and history of Critical and Speculative Design. Then, I engage with methods and practices proper to translation research going in a similar direction: transfiction, pseudotranslation, experimental translations and critical translation. On this basis I propose the possibility of Critical and Speculative Translation Fictions: combining the two approaches, introducing a participatory perspective, synergy between criticality and fiction, and an expansion of scope that sees translation as a vantage point to reflect on many socio-cultural phenomena. Next, I recount my experience in organising Speculative Transfiction workshops and integrating participatory design in critical and creative translation processes. Finally, I outline an evaluation framework combining insights from Speculative Research and Translation Studies and apply it to the workshop's products. In conclusion, my paper joins the collective efforts to highlight the epistemological value of translation.

Keywords:
radical design, experimental translation, transfiction, participatory design

1 Introduction

What is the future of translation? I have heard this question many times. From students, worried about their professional future, and from colleagues, using their research to gain insights about where the practice – and the discipline – may be going. As emerging technologies and the increasingly multilingual nature of our societies seem to continuously bring new challenges to translation, this is not a question to which any of us can find a definitive answer. It is, nevertheless, a very interesting question.

Its interest lies (also) in the fact that it is a particularly timely question. Of course, machine translation (MT) is far from being a new phenomenon (Hutchins 1995), and questions about the future of Translation Studies (TS) are also not new (Tymoczko 1998). Yet, this question is becoming more pressing, as we increasingly feel that translation has come to a crossroads. On the one side, pessimistic views describe a world where human translation is no longer necessary – or economically viable. Translation then becomes a pastime for few, while professionals end up being quality-controlling overseers of AI work. On the other side, we contemplate these visions with an acute sense of loss. We grieve at the idea of the loss *of* translation.

This grief, and a dose of stubbornness, might be the reasons behind many current efforts to show that translation is not *merely* labour, not something that can be mindlessly automated. Translation, instead, has an intrinsic epistemological value. We do learn something about the World, when we translate – and we won't anymore if we stop translating. Maybe to prove the epistemological value of translation, scholars around the world have started to insistently showcase what it can teach us about posthumanism (Cronin 2020), the arts (Gamrat 2025), city-making (Akcan 2012) and more. And maybe that's why there is resurgent interest in semiotics (Marais 2018), used to engage deeply with its processes and types. And, finally, this might be the spark that started what Lily Robert-Foley define as a "revolution" in literary translation (Robert-Foley 2024): a renewed and strong interest in artistic, creative and critical takes (see 3.2), as well as in reaching out to other creative disciplines (Vidal Claramonte 2022).

With this paper, I join these efforts to explore and experiment with the epistemological dimension of translation. In particular, I want to drive a parallel between translation and design practices aimed at the creation of knowledge and critique: namely critical and Speculative

Design. I have been experimenting with these design methods as forms of research-through-design (Gaver 2012) for several years, and I believe they have something to offer to TS – and vice versa.

2 A Brief History of Critical and Speculative Research

2.1 Radical & Critical Design

To understand their possible synergies with TS, we ought first to define Critical and Speculative Design and trace their history. The use of creativity as a way to generate knowledge is not a new idea, and it is at the base of artistic research (Kirkkopelto 2025). However, the idea that the practice of design could be a mean of societal investigation and critique emerged specifically as part of *Italian Radical Design*.

An avant-garde movement in the 1960s, Radical Design originated from a Marxist critique of the industrialisation and commodification of Western societies, and a desire to dissociate and overturn, practices that supported this system. In a moment of great success for Italian design, an increasing number of its practitioners started to question their role in the socio-industrial complex (Gregotti 1972). While some were content to design beautiful objects to be mass produced and commercialised, others were torn between the profession they were trained for, and their political ideas. How to reconcile their practice with stances that opposed industrialisation, exploitation, and the commercialisation of the imaginary? A group of Radical Designers adopted a *reformist* attitude and started to design objects with ironic and self-deprecatory tones, which challenged the contemporary assumptions and expectations (ibid.).

A second group decided that the two activities could not be reconciled: the solution was *abstinence*. Emilio Ambaaz, curator of the MoMa exhibition on this movement, illustrates the position of one of these designers in the catalogue: “[Enzo Mari] does not believe that the task of designing objects (…) has any significance today. He proposes, instead, that only valid sphere of action for the designer is that of communications” (Ambasz 1972). In the same exhibition, Gruppo Strum presented an abstract model, rather than an object, claiming that: “This is not a three-dimensional model of a reality that can be given concrete form (…) but a visual rendition of a critical attitude toward (or a hope for) the activity of designing, understood as philosophical speculation, as a means to knowledge, as critical existence.” (Ibid.).

Design, here, moves from practice to an epistemological approach. The “point”

of design, then, it is not to create new objects, but new knowledge. Even when objects are indeed created, their creation is a means of societal critique. As for why design can offer a vantage point for critique, Vittorio Gregotti (1972) claims that while some degree of capacity for renewal is inherent within the discipline itself, the reason might be rooted in the fact that design is a core language for the production and reproduction of culture in an industrialised society. Which begs the question: wouldn't translation also be a core language for the production and reproduction of culture in an increasingly multilingual and multimedia society? But let's not get ahead of ourselves.

Few decades after Radical Design, a similar design practice emerged: *critical design*. Its aim was to use design to go beyond of "what is technologically possible and semiologically consumable" and focus on "a broader context of critical thinking about its aesthetic role in everyday life." (Dunne, 1999: XV). Introduced in *Hertzian Tales*, by Antony Dunne, critical design initially focuses on electronic technologies but adopts practices that have a lot in common with Radical Design.

Critical design nowadays indicates design efforts that, regardless of the field, challenge the status quo by creating objects that are unexpected, unfamiliar, provocative or disturbing either directly, or in virtue of their supposed uses.

2.2 Design Fiction and Speculative Research

All design, and in a certain measure all creative activity, is intrinsically forward-looking, as it is oriented towards potential future users. We cannot design a chair without thinking that it will be in somebody's house, and that someone will sit on it. The same could be said about translation: translators prefigure their future readers, as well as the effect that the text they translate might have on them.

Speculative design brings this future tension to the extreme, moving not only the use of the object, but also its design, in the future. This approach emerged from a productive interference between critical design and *Design Fiction*, coined by science fiction writer Bruce Sterling. Sterling explains that: "Science fiction wants to invoke the grandeur and credibility of science for its own hand waving hocus pocus, but Design Fiction can be more practical, more hands –on. It sacrifices some sense of the miraculous, but it moves much closer to the glowing heat of techno-social conflict" (Sterling 2005). While used to describe some works of sci-fi, Design Fiction soon

becomes a research method (Blythe 2014), which essentially focuses on imagining critical design objects for more or less far futures. Speculative design comes to similar conclusions while proceeding from a design angle instead of a sci-fi one, and was conceptualised by Anthony Dunne (2008), this time with Fiona Raby (2013).

The two formulations are now used interchangeably and share the same attitude: not an attempt to predict or forecast the future, but rather its use as a way of reflecting back on the present. The future becomes a way to move the focus from technological feasibility to the ways in which new technologies might impact societies and communities.

Speculative design, however, inherited the flaws of older design ideologies, that proceed in a top-down way where the designer is invested of authority thanks to their talent, and genius. Strong criticism started to emerge and highlight how products of Speculative Design reflected the worries and fears of an educated white middle class (Tonkinwise 2014). The solution has been to move away from "authorial authority" and focus instead on *participatory design* (Spinuzzi 2005). This has been described as a way to democratise speculation (Ye & Zhang 2024), by including participants in different ways (Gil Farias et al. 2022), so that the speculations address their diverse fears, hopes, and perspectives. Designers, then, act as facilitators, rather than authors: organising series of workshops with different stakeholders and entrusting the creativity and critique to the participants (Buruk 2021). While these efforts have not been without challenges (Thibault 2024), they have been successful in widening the base of the speculations.

Speculative Design has become a recognised research method (Lindley & Coulton 2016, Baumer et al. 2020) and it has also inspired Architecture Fiction (see Marji et al. 2025), Speculative Anthropology (Ylipulli et al. 2016), Speculative Semiotics (Thibault 2023) and, in general terms, *Speculative Research* (Wilkie 2017).

My paper builds on such cross-pollination between the humanities and speculative research and aims to start a similar effort with translation.

2.3 Towards Critical and Speculative Translation Fiction

Readers from TS might have already noticed above some possible parallelisms. While engaging with the reasons why design has become a key epistemological approach to critically engage with the

present and with the future, we cannot avoid wondering if translation wouldn't be able to do the same – or if, indeed, it already has.

If design can help us understand a world of consumers, where the metaphor of "design" now encompasses all sort of creative activities (we design cities, clothes, curricula…), can't we say something similar about translation? We do live in an increasingly globalised, multilingual, and diverse world, in which even speakers of the same language are divided by epistemic differences requiring translation (Bennett 2024), where communication is not only among humans (Cronin, 2020), and intersemiotic translations are at the core of transmedia narratives dominating the creative industries (Jenkins 2007). Wouldn't TS be a perfect vantage point to speculate and critique these translational phenomena?

Just like design, TS is no longer focusing exclusively on its products, and, while using different words, it has long stated to look at translation in *a broader context of critical thinking about translations aesthetic role in everyday life* (paraphrasing Dunne, 2008: XV).

Elaborating new concepts of Critical Translation Fictions (CTF for short) and Speculative Translation Fictions (STF) can find fertile terrain in TS, where similar concepts and approaches exist and have seen considerable success. In the next paragraph I will focus on a few of these existing approaches to critical, creative, and fictional translations.

3 Critical, Creative and Fictional Translations

3.1 Translation and Fiction

Translation has a long-standing presence in different forms of fiction. *Transfiction*, in fact, has been at the centre of an intense research effort (Kaindl & Spitzl 2014, Arroyo 2017, Spitzer & Olivera 2022, Miletich 2023). Transfiction indicates the (increasingly common) introduction and use of themes related to translation into fiction. Klaus Kaindl and Karlheinz Spitzl (2014) point out that we live in a world where difference becomes a basic, pivotal characteristic to understand most human relationships. This makes translations more mundane, and more easily reflected in fiction – especially in stories focusing on travel and movement. There are many forms of transfiction, according to how accurately or realistically it is portrayed, but

also how much importance it is given in the story.

Another, key type of relationship between translation and fiction is *pseudotranslation* (Rambelli 2019): translations of an imaginary original – an often-used literary device allowing to frame a text as belonging to a different time or culture. An egregious example are the works of J.R.R. Tolkien, presented as derived from originals in the languages invented by the author. In many cases, pseudotranslations are *emancipatory* – critical – texts that have the function of commenting and providing critique on prevailing literary practices (Vanacker & Toremans 2016).

There are many different examples of both transfiction and pseudotranslations, which engage with translation with different degrees of complexity or accuracy. Both, however, seem to be perfect starting points for the establishment of CTF and STF, contributing with established practices and extensive research.

Transfiction includes future-looking works belonging to sci-fi. In many cases, the depiction of translation is that of the "Magic decoder" or the Babbel fish: ways of avoiding translation, rather than engaging with it. In other cases, they deal with constructed languages, supposedly spoken by alien races, which are a way of characterizing diversity by displaying untranslatability (Okrent 2009, Thibault 2020). Sometimes, however, there are works of future oriented transfiction that, in a similar way of Design Fiction, move much closer to the *glowing heat of (multi)linguistic conflicts*. Works such as the film *The Arrival* (Villeneuve 2016), are very close to the Spec Transfictions that I want to propose in this paper. They, however, share the same issues of Speculative Design: they are created in a top-down way by the "creative class" and often end up reflecting the preoccupations of people that are in a position of privilege.

3.2 Translation and criticality

Critical translation (Robinson 2017) is a well-established subfield in TS, and the existing bibliography on the subject is substantial, ranging from classic works on the relations between translation, power, and colonisation (Robinson 2014), to issues regarding gender (Simon 2003) and more (Valerio 2014).

We cannot do it justice, here, but clearly the existing literature is an unavoidable basis for any attempt at engaging with CTF and STF, as it systematically outlines and discusses many of the key questions for critical inquiry in regard of the practice.

There is, however, another critical approach to translation that can be an excellent starting point in our effort: that of *experimental translation* (Robert-Foley 2020): a series of creative textual practices theorised and experimented across the years. The point of departure of these efforts seems to have been a meeting, in October 2012 that gave birth to the *Outranspo* or "Ouvroir de Translation Potencial". Inspired by the Oulipo, Pablo Martín Ruiz, Camille Bloomfield, and Rachel Galvin wrote the "Acts de Fundación" simultaneously in three languages, each translating each other articles in creative and often humorous ways, as a sort of manifesto against fidelity, and an ode to the "*traduttore traditore*" (Bloomfield, Galvin & Ruiz 2016). Their aim was to challenge the value of traditional constraints while proposing freeing, playful, and imaginative new ways to deal with translation and enjoying multilingualism. Outranspo soon grew, kept experimenting, and looked for predecessors: tracing the history of homographic translations[1] or creating a bibliography on translations of constrained literature[2].

These and other provocative practices of translation are collectively named as "experimental translation" by Lily Robert-Foley (2020). In her article, the author attempts to give a more rigorous definition of the practice, recognising how, while it easy to state one's intention to go against the "norms", defining the latter is not easy, as they are culturally and historically determined. This brings Robert-Foley to highlight the political nature of experimental translation, making its criticality central to the practice. At the same time, the author underlines how these creative practices bring the translator to the forefront, overshadowing he "voice of the author" with their own. The translator is liberated from their invisibility, but they are conferred new ethical and political agency over their textual production.

This paper opened up to a phase of renewed interest in the practice, enshrined in a series of books that are published in the following years. Douglas Robinson (2022) focuses on the experimental translator, imagining for them new roles (hyper-cyborg, smugglers, collage makers) but also reconducting the practice to the traditional vocation of translation while challenging its assumptions. According to Robinson the goal of the experimental translator is to "blur the distinction and overturn the hierarchy between original creation and

[1] https://outranspo.com/homographic-translations-a-brief-history-of-the-constraint-attempts-at-trilingual-sentences/
[2] https://outranspo.com/traduire-la-litterature-a-contrainte-une-bibliographie/

derivative reproduction" (2022, 170), and, simply put, to have fun and share it with his readers. In particular, Robinson, building on Bennett and Foucault, proposes the concept of "parabolic heterotopia" as a possible function of experimental translations. The concept combine the idea of "parable" – that is, a sort of allegorical strategy inviting the reader to interpret rather than presenting a straightforward message – and that of "heterotopia" – that indicates discursive spaces that are contradictory, transformational, even disturbing. A parabolic heterotopia, then, is a text that, instead of providing an unambiguous message, uses contradiction, uncertainty, and multiplicity to provoke its readers. Robison claims that experimental translations – and pseudotranslations among them – can be parabolic heterotopias.

The same year, Tong King Lee (2022), in *Translation as Experimentalism,* focused on the concept of ludification of culture. Lee sees creative translation practices as a form of play. In the same way a game can give rise to multiple outcomes, a source text, when engaged in an experimental way, can give way to a multitude of target texts – so much that Lee defines a "new ontology of translation as a centrifugal process" (ibid., 21). The translator, like a player, faces challenges, engages in trial and error, in gambling, calculates risks and rewards.

Alexandra Lukes (2023), on the other hand, reconnects it to their avant-garde origins (again in parallel with Speculative Research and Italian Radical Design). Lukes collects many different ways to "shake up" the status quo, by aggravating their readers, questioning how translations should be read, imagining new ways of translating (like ninjas or collaborating with made-up translators) and so on. Lukes underlines, again, that while these practices might be fun, that is not their ultimate goal but a byproduct of the liberation they bring while being a tool of resistance. Lukes also underlines how experimental translation is a form of *practice-based research:* it has an epistemological dimension anchored on the vantage point that translation has: to look at intercultural and interpersonal relations.

The critical element is also at the centre of the book by Delphine Grass (2023) that looks at *Translation as Creative–Critical Practice*. Focusing on practice-based research – as well as artistic

research through translation[3]. Grass argues for the epistemological potential of these practices that she sees as capable of helping us rethink translation theory itself.

Two more key works were then published in 2024. The first is Lily Robert-Foley (2024), which highlights the links between norms such as equivalence, accuracy, and fidelity, and the capitalist and neocolonial regimes that created them (and that today are codifying them into MT and AI models). The author systematic challenges Jean-Paul Vinay and Jean Darbelnet's translation procedures by hijacking them to support deliberate mistranslations.

Simultaneously, Madeleine Campbell and Ricarda Vidal (2024) connect experimental transition to another research strand: that of *experiential* translation. The experiential quality is related to an experience that is always shared, situated, embodied, but that can be *translated* into different cultural artifacts (such as rituals, objects, texts, and so on), often in experimental ways (Vidal and Campbell 2025).

Criticality and creativity, then, are already well established in TS, and their tools, techniques and theories have been discussed, tested, and described. A few of them even engage with futuristic outlooks, such as different forms of posthuman translation (Cronin 2020, O'Thomas 2017), bridging to speculative research.

Experimental translation efforts, at the same time, are often collective, and include, for example, collaborations between artists and translators. While they might not exactly include forms of "participatory design" of their translations, the step left to take does not seem to be too long...

4 Towards Critical and Speculative Translation Fiction

4.1 Imaging a New Practice

In the previous paragraphs I have tried to showcase, though their evolution, the

[3] This in turn, should be contextualised in a renewed interest for the relations between translation at the arts, which posits the existence of a common way to look, interpret and create among artists and translators, namely an "artistranslator's gaze" (Vidal Claramonte 2022). This is, once again, a way of going beyond restrictive definitions of translation and instead focusing on it as a moment of cultural negotiation and transformation that is both creative (therefore connecting to experimental translation) and situated (connecting to experiential translation, see below).

key principles of Critical and Speculative Design and to overview the concepts, strategies, and reference works from TS that share similar preoccupations or objectives. In both parts of the paper, I have already drawn some parallelisms and highlighted some differences. Here, I want to formulate a few principles derived from this comparative work. Design and translation:

1. are both practices with an epistemological orientation. They can be used to do practice-based research and support the creation of different kinds of knowledge.
2. have both been historically oriented by capitalism and (neo)colonialism. Many of the norms and practices that are proper to their traditional views are meant to preserve the status quo and to perpetuate power imbalances.
3. have both, within their discipline, the potential to instead challenge the status quo, to provoke, to critique, to liberate, and to renew. To use this potential, we need to harness creativity and playfulness, to renegotiate the role of the designer / translator, and to expand to participatory efforts.
4. can embed criticality and creativity in the practice and simultaneously use this practice as a base for research and knowledge creation.

While I am not arguing that these four points relate only to translation and design (it would be similar with art and other creative practices), the parallelisms are striking. Both disciplines have certainly a lot to learn from each other. In this paper, I want to focus especially on what design has to offer to TS, articulated in three contributions:

1. A synergy between criticality and fiction. While, as mentioned before, there are good examples of critical transfiction, the majority of the critical work of experimental translation focuses on real source texts. This is not a flaw but an opportunity for expansion. Fictionality allows for a free space of experimentation and play, while criticality offers substance and purpose to transfiction.
2. A reorientation towards participatory methods. Enzo Manzini (2015) suggests that every person is a designer, and the role of trained designers is that of facilitating their efforts. We could make a similar argument about translation – or at least around the most creative forms of translation. When it comes to both fictional and critical translation, while collaborative works exist, there is not a framework to engage with the public or with stakeholders in a systematic way. Participatory design offers insights to continue develop these practices.
3. An expansion in scope. Design uses its metaphorical effectiveness to ground its ability to say something about every aspect of social life. Critical and Speculative Design, hence, are not afraid to talk about cities, fashion, food, transportation, gender, aging, and so on. Translation, traditionally more theoretically inclined, stops often to wonder about its own limits. But translation is also a powerful metaphor (Marais 2022) and, as experimental translation has proven, when we look at intersemiotic translation the discipline can in-

> deed have a range as wide as that of design.

If we learn from these three lessons, than we can imagine CTF and STF as a structured participatory practice, that produces translations that are either focusing on the present (Critical Translation Fiction) or on the future (Speculative Translation Fiction) but are always characterised by a critical intention and a desire to use them as an epistemological lens to look at sociolinguistic and (multi)cultural tensions, frictions, and conflicts.

4.2 Initial Experimentations

To explore the possible articulations of CTF and STF, I have organised two participatory workshops where I tested some possible methods and collected examples. In order to clarify what this practice can look like, I will briefly describe the process and its results. In bothcases I adopted a future orientation, therefore aiming to STF. Table 1 (see next page) showcases the structure of the workshops and some general information.

	Workshop 1 (WS1)	**Workshop 2 (WS2)**
Participants	n=8 (six translation scholars and two critical accounting scholars)	n=8 (all TS students)
Duration	Two hours	Three sessions of two hours
Occasion	Workshop at KäTu2024 conference	University course
Structure		
Introduction	Brief	Extensive
Brainstorming	Silly Six	Silly Six and 3-12-3
Creation	Pen and paper	Toys and objects
Presentation	To organiser and participants	To a “panel from the future”

Table 1 Structure of the STF Workshops.

Introduction: The first part was dedicated to a general introduction. In WS1, I provided an overview of the topic and objectives of the activity, while in WS2 we had a longer introduction on future-oriented methods, Speculative Design, and similar TS practices.

Brainstorming: In both workshops, the participants were divided into groups (2 in A and 3 in B) and were given a certain amount of time to come with possible ideas of future translations. In WS1 we employed the "Silly Six": a design method requiring participants to individually come up with six new ideas, in increasingly short amounts of time. The time constraint spurs creativity and encourage silly, wild, and unreasonable ideas. In WS2, we also used the "3-12-3" method (Schell 2008), where participants start from semi-random words associations and come together with a shared idea. After the brainstorming methods, participants, within their groups, had time to discuss and improve their ideas and chose one to develop.

Creation: The longest phase of the workshop. I provided creative materials to draw or build some prototypes showcasing their translations. In WS1 participants had pens and paper, while in WS2 more complex workshop materials (toys, cardboard, etc.). In WS2, we first engaged some basics of short story writing and persona creation, including the idea of future arcs (Dator 2020), and four-character archetypes (Noortman 2021): the students imagined one or more characters related to their idea and positioned them in a story. The key part of the activity was then to create their STFs. Io order to guide the creation process I gave some additional guidance in the form of a list of topics to keep in mind or questions to ponder (Table 2).

WS1	WS2
- Product (make up a short translation from the future) - Context (make a scenario in which translations are needed) - Process (imagine a new way to create translations) - Participants (imagine fictional people or posthumans involved)	1 – What does it translate? 2 – What kind of critique it entails? 3 – What does it speculate? 4 – What kind of world does it exist in? 5 – What kind of contradiction does it bring?

Table 2 STF workshops guiding principles.

Presentation: In WS1, each group showcased and explained their translation to the others, while I facilitated a discussion about them and their critical dimensions. In WS2, the students presented their projects to a panel of experts "from the future". The panel was composed by three experts (postdocs in posthuman design, interactive media and future research, and semiotics and gamification) which impersonated characters from the future (with costumes), asked questions and offered provocations. Both I and the teaching assistants also pretended to be facilitators from the future. The future expert panel is meant to encourage the students to be silly and creative, but also as a means for *dépaysment* and taking distance from the present.

With the consent of the participants, I recorded the presentations and the material representations of the speculative translations as data to be analysed.

4.3 A Few Speculative Translation Fictions

The workshops produced 5 STFs, one for each of the groups. As the projects did not have explicit titles, I have assigned each a short handle (Table 3) for ease of discussion.

WS1 Group 1	**Posthuman**
WS1 Group 2	**Shapeshifting**
WS2 Group 1	**Tree MT**
WS2 Group 2	**Rogue**
WS2 Group 3	**Emoji**

Table 3 Handles of the STFs.

Posthuman. WS1's Group 1 focused on an interspecies translation project (fig 1., left). In a future where human-tree communication has been established, companies create sustainability reports about biodiversity for trees as well. Reports cannot be printed on paper anymore (as it is derived from trees) but the material will be literally taken "from the back" of human beings. The reports are then deposited on the ground next to the roots of the trees.

Shapeshifting. WS1's Group 2 imagined an artifact from the far future, capable of changing shape when touched by a living being to reflect – or translate in plastic form – their current emotional and cognitive state (Fig.1, right). This object will be made by human beings, but further on, after the end of humanity, will be found by aliens exploring the ruins of Earth. When an alien touches the artifact, however, it immediately changes

shape to reflect their own state of being. The participants then speculated about how the aliens could understand the purpose of the artifact, and how then they could translate its last human-made shape in something intelligible for their species.

Tree MT. WS2's Group 1 focused human-tree communication and was based on the idea of training AI models that would be able to translate bio signals from the trees into natural languages and vice-versa. The speculation focused on the scientists creating the model and communicating with the trees, and their different attitudes towards MT.

Rogue. WS2's Group 2 presented the translation of a message from a powerful and evil dictator/CEO meant for an alien race. While the original message was full of demands and threats, the rogue translators, among the few

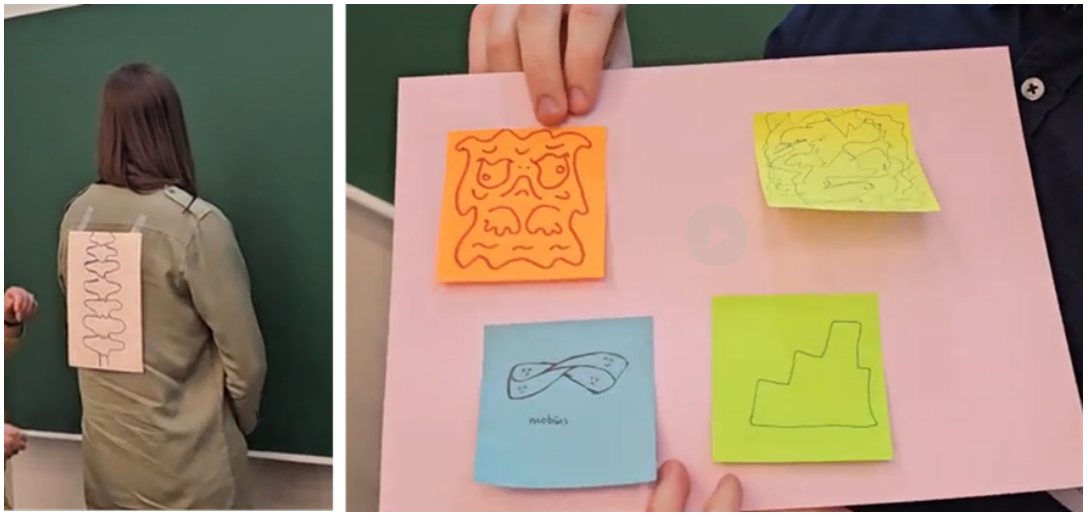


Figure 1 The STFs created at the KäTu2024 conference workshop.

individuals knowing the alien language, took a lot of liberties to create a target text that was more respectful and friendly.

Emoji. WS2's Group 3 imagined a future in which all natural languages suddenly and mysteriously disappeared. People, unable to communicate, started to rely on the technological affordances around them and to use emojis as a base for communication. The students also showcased a text in its original English and in its emoji translation.

4.4 Evaluation

4.4.1 Evaluating the STFs

The necessity, and difficulty, of evaluating speculations is something that has been much debated. Joseph Lindley and

Paul Coulton (2016) engaged with the difficulty of peer-reviewing speculative research in a moment when these methods were emerging. Later, Baumer et al. (2020) suggested that the key questions would be "What are researchers, designers, practitioners, etc. trying to achieve by deploying them?" (ibid. 1910). More recently, Ringfort-Felner et al. (2025) engaged in a systematic literature review to outline the key qualities of good Speculative Design. This resulted in a list including three *speculative* qualities – being "fictional", "critical" and "socio-political" – two *discursive* qualities – being "experienceable" and "thought-provoking" – and four processual qualities – being "grounded", "participative", "reflective", and "playful".

I believe this is an excellent stating point to ground our evaluation as well. To paraphrase Baumer and colleagues, these criteria are well in line with what I am trying to achieve by deploying STF.

Nevertheless, the qualities proposed are centred around practices related to design and therefore need some adaptation and rethinking before being adapted to translation. I propose then a series of changes and partial reformulations to the original list, as showcased in Table 4.

Quality	Description
Fictional	Constructs an imaginative context to set the translation in, enabling creativity and exploration.
Critical	Challenges existing norms (translatorial, social, cultural), supports critical reflection, promotes counternarratives – works as a parabolic heterotopia.
Socio-political	Engages with social and political conflicts, using translation as a lens to look at broader communicational, mediatic, and technological dimensions – and the implications of their evolutions.
Textualized	Transforms abstract concepts in specific textual forms, crystallising tensions, enhancing understanding and fostering debate.
Thought-provoking	Opens up to questions, reflection, and debate, eliciting audience engagement and contemplation on a subject.
Grounded	Is solidly constructed on linguistic, translational, and semiotic understandings of different forms of translation.
Participative	Actively involves diverse stakeholders in both the creation and the critical reflection, including non-translators and marginalized groups.
Self-aware	Incorporate a self-reflection of the participants positionality, modes of communication, and potential biases.
Playful	Adopts exploratory and creative approaches, embraces silliness and risk-taking, and encourages unconventional thinking.

Table 4 Qualities of STF, variation of the typology by Ringfort-Felner et al. (2025).

Beyond minor changes, bringing translation in the spotlight, I have reworked some of the qualities:

Critical: this dimension connects fruitfully to critical TS, but also to the idea of *parabolic heterotopia* (Robinson 2022), as it engages with the ability of STF to provoke using openness, contradiction, and multiplicity, challenging its audience to make sense of it.

Socio-political: this is key both for design and transition (which, as mentioned above, has many socio-political implications, see Robinson 2014 and 2017). As translation offers different vantage points, I modified it to focus especially on the importance of difference as basic relation in human societies (Kaindl & Spitzl 2014), translation in fragmented and convergent cultures (Jenkins 2006), and the two-way relation between translation and politics (Robert-Foley 2020).

Textualized: while Design Fiction is artifact-oriented, transfiction is textual-oriented. Crystallising one's critical speculations in an actual translation – no matter how experimental or fantastic – is the best way to stay true to the concept. These texts can take the shape of many different artifacts (including rituals, performances, gestures), translating other texts, but also experiences (Vidal and Campbell 2025) and emotions (Gamrat 2025).

Grounded: rather than in scientific research, STF needs to be strongly grounded in theory from linguistics, TS, and semiotics. For the speculation to be meaningful, the translation itself needs to be coherent and conform to our current understanding in regard of translation and communication.

Self-aware: While Ringfort-Felner et al. (2025) name this category "reflective", I find that formulation confusing and prefer "self-aware" – a quality that is also very much connected to translators.

Playful: The playful quality in our case can be expanded to include Lee's (2022) characterization of the ludic translator, adding to the ideas of freedom and exploration, also those of the challenge, of risk-taking, and of mastery.

Now that I have compiled a list of criteria, I can apply them to the scenarios created in the workshops. As my aim is to focus on methodological development, I will look at the general strengths and shortcoming of the STFs created in the two workshops.

All the STFs seem to have some common strengths and weaknesses. All of them, for example, are good at fictionality and

playfulness: the scenarios and translation are fantastic and far from everyday life, engaging with posthuman entities, inexistent technologies, or mysterious circumstances. Both in the creation and presentations participants where playful, often recurring to role-play and choosing challenging scenarios. All of them, while maybe not living up to the status of parabolic heterotopias, were in some measure thought-provoking, eliciting discussions about: the use of biological materials as media, and the use of metaphors for envisioning futures (Posthuman), materiality, experience, radical alterity, untranslatability (Shapeshifting), the shortcomings of AI translation between radically different beings (Tree MT), translation and activism and authoriality on the target text (Rogue) and the role of young people in renewing language (Emoji).

While all scenarios presented some critical elements, only a few (Posthuman, Rogue) directly engaged with the sociopolitical dimension in a non-trivial way, while many did not engage such questions. Similarly, some of the creations did present a textual form showcasing a translation (Tree MT, Rogue, Emoji), others only described the translation without showcasing it.

The Grounding of the STFs varied. Some engaged with the key mechanisms of translation (experiential translation in Shapeshifting, AI translation in Tree MT), other presented ideas that disregarded them (the Emoji translation, for example, was made by a word-by-word replacement of verbal elements with visual ones, which left a very large space of ambiguity), or seemed to engage with translation in a loosely metaphorical way (Posthuman).

The two qualities that were probably the weakest are Participative and Self-aware – both responsibility of the organiser. I expressly decided to focus on testing these methodologies with people familiar with TS first, therefore, while participatory, the workshops were not diverse in terms of stakeholders. This can be a challenge in the future as well, as finding stakeholders capable of engaging in creative forms of translation without any previous specialist knowledge might be difficult. Finding ways to facilitate this kind of workshops for a diverse audience will be an important future development. As for self-awareness, I did not explicitly request it from the participants, and it will also be an important addition to future workshops.

4.4.2 Evaluating the Learning Experience

WS2 was part of a course, so it can be relevant to engage with what the students report to have learned from it, as an additional way of reflecting over the experience and its epistemological qualities. Few students (n=3) offered feedback through the university portal, while all of them (n=8) mentioned the workshops in their learning diaries. I have collected all their feedback, created affinity diagrams, and identified four key topics:

Enjoyment: Many students referred to WS2 as fun or mentioned other students having fun. One student mentioned having a "great time", while another explained they were "confused yet delighted" after hearing the course instructions. Fun is strictly related to playfulness, one of the key qualities I was aiming to. Nevertheless, it can also make participants lose sight of criticality (see Thibault 2024), so it should be treated with care.

Criticality: Several students reported the workshop and the expert panel to be "thought-provoking". Some mentioned having to think outside of the box, and one detailed one specific question that acutely picked their interest as part of the discussion of another group's scenario ("who do we allow to be a translator?"). Criticality is indeed one of the key objectives of the workshop, and therefore students reporting being provoked is encouraging.

Learning: A few students explicitly reported what they have learned from the course, including: using their imagination, widening their understanding of what translation can be about, how self-reflection can be a way of creating knowledge, and the fact that future speculations can be means of reflection on the present. The reported lessons learned suggest that students appreciated understanding the reasons behind organising such a workshop, rather that what they have learned though the creation of STFs.

Challenges: Several students highlighted challenges, both in a positive light ("stressful and it was not easy, but it was motivating") and outlining some shortcomings (lack of time, being caught in tunnel vision about their own project). While offering some avenues for developing the process further, the comments seemed to paint the picture of being faced by something unexpected ("the critical questions asked did scare me at first", "I felt a little overwhelmed with the (creative) freedom") but ultimately enjoyable.

5 Conclusions

The two workshops were simultaneously ways to develop my approach to Critical and Speculative Translation Fiction and to test the effectiveness of few methods from participatory design in this setting. The results of these exploratory efforts are limited and preliminary, but they have been encouraging: the STFs of all groups were critical, exploratory and playful, and, while there is ample space to strengthen future ones (in terms of textualization, socio-political engagement, and grounding), I believe their quality to be rather good for first attempts. The self-reports of the students of WS2 seem to confirm the critical and playful sides, while indicating a way forward in the organisation of future workshops to allow more time to explore ideas. The main future challenge might be including non-translators in this kind of workshops. A possible strategy could be mixed groups, which I am currently investigating in a new iteration of the course (with also students of architecture and game studies).

This paper, in conclusion, is meant a theoretical and methodological starting point. I will continue to integrate methods and insights from TS and design – in the hope that others will join me in this effort.

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